

1 / The world of work today

a) The main weakness: unemployment in Europe

- before the current recession:
 - widespread relocations
 - outsourcings
- today:



- **unemployment rate** has reached unprecedented levels in many European countries (25% in Spain and Greece)
- countries deprived of a **strong and competitive industrial network**

b) Conflicting solutions

- reducing **labour costs** and abandoning the **welfare state** (lower **labour taxes**, reduce pensions, postpone the **retirement age**)
- increasing flexibility
- abandoning the minimum wage
- abolishing the **labour laws**
- trusting the market only
- or
- increasing companies' **taxes on profits**
- taxing **shareholders** and financial transactions
- increasing or maintaining public spending in order to prevent a dangerous rise in poverty
- implementing **vocational training** for **jobless** workers
- cracking down on tax evasion

2 / Today's workforce

a) An ageing workforce ...

- EU and US: the number of people over 65 will have doubled in 2050
- finding a new job after the age of 55 is almost impossible
- older workers are more liable to be laid off to be replaced by younger staff with lower **salaries**

b) ... and yet few jobs for the young

- EU: too many young people unemployed
- they are increasingly encouraged to carry out a succession of unpaid **work placements** delaying their entry in the work market
 - Many young Europeans have started to look for better work opportunities abroad (Australia, Canada, New Zealand, etc.).

c) Lasting discriminations

- **gender discrimination** is still a topical issue
 - A majority of women earn less than their male **counterparts** for the same job.

Enrichir son vocabulaire

- **unemployment**: chômage
- **recession**: récession
- **relocation**: déménagement
- **outsourcing**: sous-traitance / externalisation

- **unemployment rate**: taux de chômage
- **industrial network**: réseau industriel

- The **welfare state** is a government which protects and promotes the economic and social well-being of its citizens.
- **labour costs**: coûts de main-d'œuvre
- **labour taxes**: taxes sur le travail
- **retirement age**: age du départ à la retraite
- **labour laws**: lois du travail
- **taxes on profits**: taxes sur les bénéfices
- **shareholder**: actionnaire
- **vocational training**: formation professionnelle
- **jobless**: sans emploi / au chômage

- **work placement**: stage

- **discrimination**: discrimination
- **recruiter**: recruteur

Enrichir son vocabulaire

- trade union: syndicat
- unionised worker: employé syndiqué
- social unrest: agitation sociale
- short-term contract: contrat à court terme
- temporary job: emploi temporaire / en CDD
- permanent job: emploi permanent / en CDI
- benefits: avantages sociaux
- health coverage: assurance maladie
- sick leave: arrêt maladie
- real estate: immobilier
- open space office: espace open space

- commitment: engagement
- teleworking / telecommuting: télétravail

- to commute: faire le trajet du travail à chez soi
- schedule: horaire
- carbon footprint: empreinte carbone

- teamwork: travail en équipe
- clocking in: badger / pointer à l'arrivée au travail
- clocking out: badger / pointer à la sortie du travail

- ethnic and religious discrimination may also exist depending on the EU country minorities live in.

d) Trade unions

- Their role is to defend the interests of workers and employees.
- EU: on the decline for the past 30 years due to the disappearance of many industrial jobs (most unionised workers used to be factory workers, miners, steel workers etc.)
- yet in some countries like Germany they are part of the companies' decision-making process
- ➔ A better understanding between employers and employees avoids social unrest.

e) today's employees must accept ...

- a long succession of short-term contracts and temporary jobs before getting a permanent job
- longer unemployment periods
- lower and shorter unemployment benefits
- fewer benefits (less health coverage, lower pensions, etc.)
- ➔ Today's employees must be flexible in order to adapt to the ups and downs of demands in an unstable market.

3 / Today's work place

- The rising prices of real estate has prompted companies to change today's workplace.
- massive use of open space offices: little if no privacy
- employees feel under the constant pressure of management
- but also new eco-friendly workplaces: to make employees more comfortable
- to increase their commitment to the company they work for
- rise of teleworking or telecommuting
- employees are encouraged to work from their homes or outside the office several days a week.
- ➔ Thanks to new technologies such as an omnipresent and faster Internet access.
- the main advantages for employees:
 - to allow them to organise their own schedule
 - to allow parents to take their children to and from school
 - to reduce their carbon footprint (no commuting ➔ no transports ➔ no pollution)
- the main drawbacks for employees:
 - to be cut off from their colleagues
 - less teamwork ➔ negative impact on innovation
 - no more clear line between work and private life
 - no clocking in or out
 - no trade union to defend their rights in case of conflicts

Do you know?

1. Which part of the population is the most affected by unemployment?
2. What is the situation of many young people in the EU?
3. Are men and women equal at the workplace?
4. What are the advantages and drawbacks of teleworking?